It helped the BJP that, compared to the IPFT, another state tribal outfit, the Indigenous Nationalist Party of Twipra (INPT) led by former militant-turned-leader Bijoy Kumar Hrangkhaw, could not strike a chord with the Janjati population. This is why Amit Shah made it a point to stress in his victory speech that the party's pro-tribal outreach had worked. The BJP–IPFT won all twenty ST-reserved seats in Tripura, with the IPFT winning eight of the nine seats it contested.[96] The challenges of this alliance became clearer in 2019, when the IPFT's insistence on Twipraland meant that the IPFT and the BJP, while remaining allies in the state government, fought against each other in Tripura's two seats in the national election. 'Ideological differences with the BJP are there,' IPFT's general secretary and the tribal welfare minister in the alliance government, Mevar Kumar Jamatia, was quoted as saying. 'Being a regional party, our focus is on regional issues such as the demand for a separate Twipraland in the scheduled areas.'[97] Even so, the fact that the unlikely alliance persisted on the state level showed that the BJP was prepared to be pragmatic and make compromises for political gains in the region.

NAGALAND'S SPLIT-AND-MERGE MODEL

The BJP's challenge in Nagaland, a Christian-majority state, was of a very different order from what it faced in Tripura. The apex body of Baptist churches, the Nagaland Baptist Churches Council, had directly attacked the party, accused it of being anti-minorities and asked believers not to support those who sought to 'pierce the heart of Jesus Christ'.[98] In such a situation, the BJP needed local faces and much more flexibility. Though it had a fifteen-year-old alliance with the NPF, some senior leaders from its long-time ally too accused the party of being anti-Christian in the months leading up to the 2018 assembly election. NPF leader and former Nagaland chief minister, Shurhozelie Liezietsu, for example, reportedly told voters that the BJP had a larger agenda of declaring India a 'Hindu Rashtra'. 'If the BJP comes to power in this Christian state,' he said at a public meeting in Kohima, 'they [the BJP] will tell the rest of the world that, since Christian Nagaland has voted for BJP, Christians want to convert to Hinduism and then they will force us into